the judgment, the Supreme Court recognised the chilling effect of overbroad restrictions on free speech. This judgment too remains a landmark one for its contribution to free speech jurisprudence, especially in the context of online platforms.[5]

While these cases certainly presented me with fantastic opportunities to apply my understanding of constitutional law to IPR and technology-related contexts and vice versa, my brush with constitutional law from a civilisational perspective first and truly began after I set up independent practice, exclusively as an arguing counsel in June 2016. Fortunately, since I had earned my stripes as a litigator by then, my peers in the legal fraternity supported my decision, which kept me in good stead as an arguing counsel in civil commercial matters as well as in writ petitions before the Delhi High Court and the Supreme Court.

It was around then that Senior Advocate Shri C.S. Vaidyanathan,[6] one of the leading lights of the Supreme Court, recommended me to the team that, till date, steers the writ petition[7] ('the HRCE Petition') moved before the Apex Court by the Late Swami Dayananda Saraswati.[8] The HRCE Petition, which is yet to be decided by the Supreme Court, challenges the constitutionality of the key provisions of the Tamil Nadu Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (TNHRCE) Act, 1959, the Andhra Pradesh Charitable and Hindu Religious Institutions and Endowments Act, 1987 and the Pondicherry Hindu Religious Institutions Act, 1972 ('the HRCE Acts') for violating Articles 14, 15(1), 19(1)(g), 21, 25, 26 and 29 of the Constitution.

The more I read the HRCE Petition and the material assiduously put together by the team in support of the petition, the more it convinced me that there was a clear causal link between State control of Hindu temples and the visible degradation of the temple ecosystem. Also, I came to the jarring realisation that a legal framework as invasive as the HRCE Acts was reserved for Hindu religious institutions alone. I learnt of similar Hindu-specific legislations that were in force in Karnataka, Kerala, Odisha and several other States. Given the significant questions of constitutional law involved in the HRCE Petition, such as the nature and role of the Indian State, its relationship with religion and its treatment of religious institutions of different faiths, I was keen on contributing to the matter. I joined the team as an arguing counsel on a pro bono basis, which gave me the opportunity to work alongside eminent Senior Counsels, such as Shri C.S.